

Seem

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Episode 1: The Wrong Kind of Man

Three streams. **Bold** is sound. (*SURFACE*) is spoken in the room. (*CHORD*) is the channel — layered, roomless, cold; it is one voice short. (*HIM*) is Daniel's interior — warm, roomed, his feelings arriving a beat after they are planted. *NARRATOR* is Wren, years later, reconstructing; she cannot hear the *CHORD*. The listener hears everything. Daniel hears only the room and himself. Wren hears only the room. See the *README*.

Black. Then a man's voice, alone — close, ordinary, and wrong. The words are friendly. The life under them is gone, like a recording of warmth played one too many times.

MAN (*SURFACE* — flat, patient, the colour turned down out of him): No — no, you go on ahead. I'm grand. (*beat*) I'm always grand. (*beat*) ... Funny. I used to be such good company.

Silence. Let that sit. Then NARRATOR — close, dry, certain. This is the contract; do not hurry it.

NARRATOR: That's a man I brought home to my family. (*beat*) I brought a lot of men home, over the years. And afterwards — every one of them — they were never quite men again. (*beat*) That one was *loud* when I found him. Loud and lonely and full of himself, opinions on everything, a band he'd seen, an ex-wife he wasn't over. He walked into my family one Sunday like a man coming in out of the rain. (*beat*) And he walked out again, after. They all walked out after. Alive. On their own two feet. (*beat*) Just — turned down. Like a radio in another room. All the words still in them. No song left underneath.

A breath.

NARRATOR: I did it for thirty years, and thought it was the one thing wrong with me — that I couldn't keep one. That I always picked the kind who'd drift off toward somebody else the moment they got warm. (*a small dry sound*) *I always meet the wrong kind of man.* My mother used to say it like a weather report, and I believed her, because she was never wrong about anything. (*beat*) It took me thirty years and one funeral to understand. I wasn't unlucky. I wasn't picking them wrong. (*very quiet*) I was the bait.

The faintest hum begins under her — low, layered, many voices breathing as one, no words in them. And in the hum, a hole. A place a voice should sit, and doesn't.

NARRATOR: It only ever worked because nobody looked at me twice. (*beat*) That was the gift, they told me — the only one I had. I could go quiet inside for a man until he felt seen for the first time in his life — and then, when my family came and took him, I could disappear so completely he'd forget I was ever in the room. (*beat*) You can't bait a hook the fish keeps staring at. (*beat*) I was good at not being seen. I'd had a lifetime's practice. In my own house.

A beat.

NARRATOR: This is the last man I ever brought home. His name was Daniel. (*beat*) And I'm going to tell you the worst of it now, so you don't sit there hoping: he walked out the way they all walked out. Turned down. He's alive somewhere this minute, not knowing what he lost, or that he lost it. (*beat*) He was the last because he was the only one who ever turned it around. The only man who looked *back* at me. Who saw me — when seeing me was the one thing the whole house was built to prevent. (*beat*) And that. Not a knife, not

a drug, nothing with a name. *That* is what brought it all down. (*very quiet*) My one good man. I should have left him in the rain.

The hum settles back, very faint. The house comes up around it — old timber settling, a clock somewhere, unhurried. And under all of it, the layered breathing. The hole in it. Hold the hole. Let the ear lean toward it and find nothing.

NARRATOR (*close, unhurried*): It started the week we buried my grandmother. (*beat*) The house went quiet in a way I didn't have a word for. It was never a loud house — my family didn't argue, they never had to. They'd settle a thing between them before anyone got as far as a sentence, the way you don't argue with your own hand about which way to turn a key.

The hum, under. The hole in it.

NARRATOR: But that week it went *thin*. Like a chord with a note lifted out of it. I kept thinking the radiators had been turned down. I kept checking. They hadn't. (*beat*) I was the only one in the house who couldn't feel what was actually missing. I just felt cold, and assumed, the way I always assumed, that the cold was something the matter with me.

A door. Footsteps — not hers; older, certain. A long pause in a doorway. Then the footsteps move off. A breath let out that has too many breaths in it, layered, just under hearing — and then only one woman breathing, in a kitchen, somewhere.

NARRATOR: My mother stood in doorways that week. She'd never done that in her life. She'd go to a room and then stop at the edge of it like she'd forgotten what rooms were *for*. (*softer*) I brought her tea. I didn't know what else a person does. She looked at me —

A pause. The clock.

NARRATOR: — she looked at me like she was counting, and had come up one short, and was trying to work out whether I was the one she could send.

The hum swells, very slightly. Hungry is the wrong word. But the room wants something. Hold — then:

NARRATOR: By the Thursday she sent me out. She didn't say *go and find someone*. She never said it like that. She said, *you're no use to me moping, love, go and be among people*. (*a small breath*) And I went, grateful, the way a dog is grateful to be given a job. I didn't know I'd been given one. (*beat*) I never did. Until it was far too late to give it back.

A cut. New acoustic — a café, a warm wash of noise, a coffee machine. This memory comes fast and flat, almost bored.

NARRATOR: Let me show you how it works, with one who doesn't matter. So you don't have to take my word for it later. (*beat*) I don't remember his name. I want that on the record — that I can stand here and tell you exactly how a man I sat with for two hours folded and unfolded a sugar packet, and I cannot give you his name, because I never once needed it.

Café. A man's voice, mid-thirties, lonely-friendly, the kind that's grateful to be talked to.

MAN (*SURFACE*): — no, you go ahead, I'm not — honestly I'm just glad of the company, it's been a — it's been a week.

NARRATOR (*over it, flat*): It's always been a week. Every man I ever brought home had just had a week. (*beat*) And the only thing I was ever good at is that I'd listen. Not the way people pretend to. All the way down. Until a man feels, maybe for the first time since he was small, that there's a person across the table who's gone quiet inside *for him*.

MAN (*SURFACE, lower, opening*): Can I tell you something I haven't — I don't know why I'm —

NARRATOR: And then I'd bring him home. And then —

The café noise drops away abruptly, replaced by that cold, layered, roomless CHORD — and the hole in it. This is the first time the listener hears the channel. Make it feel like a door opening onto a room with no air in it.

CHORD (*cold, layered, close, no room around it; one voice short*): Adequate. (*beat*) Not for the budding. For the table. Bring him to the daughter. The daughter will take it from here.

NARRATOR (*plain*): — and then he stopped being mine. He turned, the way they all turned, toward my sister, like a plant turning to a window. And I sat in my own family like a coat somebody had taken off. (*beat*) That one I'd see again. Years later. A bus, a supermarket — the colour turned down out of him, *whoever you are* to a girl he used to know loud. (*beat*) And I'd think — *poor man, life does that to people* — and pick up my shopping, and go home to the family that did it. (*very quiet*) Thirty years. I never once let myself finish the question.

The café fades entirely. Rain rises in its place — steady, against glass.

NARRATOR: That's the shape. Now the one that mattered. The last man I ever brought home to them. (*beat*) And remember, when I get there — I'm asking you a favour — remember that I walked into it grateful. That's the part I can't make soft for you. Nobody made me. I went because being sent was the closest thing to being wanted I had.

RAIN, steady, against glass. A near-empty café-bar, late. A coffee machine sighs and goes quiet. One chair scrapes. Room tone settles. Hold it — let the place be real before anyone is.

NARRATOR (*close*): This is the last one. I didn't know that yet. (*a small breath*) What I remember isn't his face. It's that he folded his receipt into a tiny square while he talked, smaller and smaller, like he was trying to make it disappear before he had to ask anyone for anything. (*beat*) I wasn't supposed to notice things like that. Noticing things like that was exactly what was wrong with me.

A glass set down, gentle. The man's voice — DANIEL — close, a little tired, warm.

DANIEL (*SURFACE*): You don't have to keep me company, you know. I'm a big believer in letting people off the hook.

NARRATOR (*over it*): I brought him in with nothing but talk. That part was always mine. I sat down across from a stranger in a dead bar in the rain, and inside twenty minutes he was telling me the true things. (*beat*) The rest — the part that comes after the talk — was never mine to do.

The acoustic shifts subtly — we are at a table now. Two more presences arrive, settle. A warmth comes into the air that is almost too much, too soon. A chair. A coat.

LISS (*SURFACE — warm, easy, bright*): So you're the one who's been keeping her all to yourself.

DANIEL (*SURFACE — a laugh, a little nervous*): I — sorry, I didn't realize I was keeping anyone.

CHORD (*cold, layered, roomless — the gap where the third voice should be*): He apologizes for taking up space. Good. Easily moved. Bring the daughter into his eyeline. Take him off the sister. Let him find the right one.

NARRATOR (*over it, dry*): And every time — *every* time — I'd watch them turn. Like that. The moment I'd warmed a man up, he'd swing toward whoever I'd brought him to, and I'd tell myself I just wasn't the kind men stay pointed at. (*beat*) I had the cause backwards. But that took me thirty years and one funeral to work out.

A small thing — and the listener should clock that no CHORD line precedes it.

DANIEL (*HIM — interior, warm, slightly wondering*): ...God. The sister. How did I not — she was right there when we came in. How did I not *see* her?

CHORD (*a small recalculation, cold*): He drifts. Note it. (*flat*) Draw him forward. The daughter holds his eye; the sister fades back. The sister is always to fade back. That is what she is *for*.

LISS (*SURFACE — softer now, leaning in*): What brings you here, then? Really.

DANIEL (*SURFACE*): Honestly? Killing time. A friend bailed. (*self-deprecating*) Story of my — you don't need my whole sad —

VALA (*SURFACE — first time she speaks; mild, grandmotherly, almost nothing there*): We don't mind a sad story. We've heard worse.

CHORD: The mother is right. We have heard worse. (*a flat ripple — the nearest this voice comes to amusement*) He answers to being needed. So. Need him.

DANIEL (*HIM — a flicker, almost nothing, gone before he can hold it*): ...funny how they all — they answer like one person. The mother, the sister, like they've already had the conversation somewhere I can't hear it. (*and he waves it off, warming it into the thing he wants*) No. That's just close. That's what close looks like. (*quieter*) I've never had that. I'd give anything to be let inside something that close.

LISS (*SURFACE*): Then stay. Sit with us a while. It's filthy out there, and you'd be doing us a kindness — it's been a hard week.

RAIN, harder against the glass.

DANIEL (*HIM — and this is the seam: let the line above arrive in his own warm voice, a beat too soon to be his*): ...they've had a hard week. I could — yeah. I could be useful. (*quieter, to himself*) When's the last time anyone actually needed me to just *sit* with them.

NARRATOR: He said yes to the rain, really. To not being alone in it. (*beat*) And I want to be clear: I knew exactly what was happening. I'd done it a hundred times. I just couldn't, for the life of me, work out why this time it felt like watching someone walk into traffic.

CHORD: The daughter has him. (*beat*) Step back. (*and now — the one instruction the listener already understands has teeth*) Step back.

A pause. A chair, very slightly, moves back from the table. LISS and DANIEL's voices continue underneath now — warm, indistinct, a private weather forming without our narrator in it.

NARRATOR (*quieter, the dryness gone*): So I stepped back. The way you're meant to. And I sat in my own family like a coat someone had taken off and forgotten, and I watched him fall for my sister with a look on his face like something good was finally happening to him. (*beat*) And I was jealous. (*she catches it — almost laughs at herself*) Jealous. Of course I was. After everything, *that* was the rot they could never quite cut out of me.

The two warm voices, close and happy, under. Rain. Then a small private sound: paper, folded, refolded. The receipt. DANIEL, mid-laugh at something Liss has said, fingers working at it without knowing.

NARRATOR: While my sister did the thing she was made to do, I watched his hands. He'd finished the receipt — folded it down past the point paper wants to fold, this hard little square — and now he didn't know what to do with it, so he turned it over and over, this man who was, by every account including his own, having the best night of his life. (*beat*) People who are happy don't do that with their hands. (*beat*) I noticed. Nobody had asked me to. Nobody ever did.

A burst of LISS's laughter, bright. DANIEL laughing too — but listen: under his laugh, the HIM voice, low, not unhappy, just true.

DANIEL (*HIM*): ...this is going to end. Things like this always — (*he stops himself*) No. Be here. For once just *be* here.

CHORD: He guards himself. Naturally. (*flat*) The daughter will not rush. We have time.

NARRATOR (*very quiet*): I didn't hear that, of course. The cold part. I never could. (*beat*) But I'm going to tell it to you anyway, all the way through, because somebody should have heard it, and I'm the only one left who'd want to.

The clock from the opening, faint, returning under. The thin hum, the hole in it.

NARRATOR: They didn't say it out loud that night. But I know how my family talks when it's decided something. There's a — settling. The way the house had gone thin all week, that Thursday it went *still*, the way a held breath is still. (*beat*) I thought it was about my grandmother. I thought we were grieving. (*beat*) We were. I just didn't understand that in my family, grief and hunger are the same weather.

CHORD (*under, cold, certain*): This one. (*beat*) Not the table. (*beat*) This one is for the line.

NARRATOR: I'm guessing at the words. But I'd bet my life on them. (*a breath*) I nearly did.

Outside now. The café door, a bell. Rain on the street. DANIEL and WREN, walking, the acoustic open and wet. Liss and Vala gone ahead or behind — for a moment it is just the two of them, and this is the only stream the listener can fully trust.

DANIEL (*SURFACE, warmer, looser, the wine in it*): Can I say a weird thing. (*beat*) Your sister's — your whole family's lovely, they really are, they've been so —

WREN (*SURFACE — and this is the first we hear her in scene,* younger, lighter, careful*):* But.

DANIEL (*SURFACE*): No, not but. (*beat*) It's just — you're the one who talked to me. Like, *talked*. And then you sort of — went away. And I keep — (*small laugh at himself*) I don't know. I keep wanting to check you're still there.

A beat. Rain. And here — crucially — no CHORD line comes before this. Nothing is planted. It is only him.

DANIEL (*HIM — quiet, unforced, and the listener must be able to tell this one is real*): She's got the saddest, kindest face. Why would they keep someone like that at the edge of everything.

WREN (*SURFACE — and she misreads it, the way she always will*): I'm always still here. (*beat, dry, deflecting*) I'm the furniture. You'll learn.

NARRATOR (*over, present-day, and it costs her*): He said a true thing to me, in the rain, and I made a joke, because a true thing said to me had to be a mistake. Someone had got the wrong girl. (*beat*) I have gone back to that sentence — *I keep wanting to check you're still there* — more nights than I'll admit. (*beat*) And here is the one thing I'd stake what's left of me on: nobody *gave* him that. (*beat*) The warmth my family aimed at my sister — every soft word of it — was *made*. I'd watched it being made a hundred times. (*beat*) But no one ever stood at a man's shoulder and told him to wonder where I'd gone. (*very quiet*) That he did on his own. It was the one feeling in that whole house that was nobody's idea but his. (*beat*) What I'll never know is whether it would have grown into the thing I've spent thirty years calling it. I couldn't hear the part of him that might have told me. (*beat*) I only ever got the room.

RAIN. Then the warm voices fold back in — Liss returning, laughing, slipping her arm through Daniel's. The private weather closing over again. WREN, half a step back, where she belongs.

LISS (*SURFACE, bright, drawing him on*): Come *on*, you two, you'll catch your deaths — Daniel, you're staying for tea, I won't hear otherwise —

DANIEL (*SURFACE, swept, happy*): I — okay, yeah, okay —

CHORD: Good. He comes willingly. (*beat*) But mark it: he turned to the sister, twice. He *looks* at her. (*flat — and for the first time, something the listener should hear as a threat*) That cannot be. The daughter will hold him closer. The sister will be kept further back. No man we keep is ever to look at the sister twice.

A beat. Then, into the gap where the third voice is not —

CHORD: ... And we are short. (*flat, not grief — a hand reaching for a tool that is not on the bench*) We are short, and we will not stay short.

The hole in the chord, loud now in its silence. Then the rain swallows it.

NARRATOR: That's where I'll stop tonight. Him saying yes a second time — yes to the tea, yes to the warmth, yes to all of it — and me a step behind, jealous, useless, *noticing*. (*beat*) They'd already decided what he was for. I didn't have the word for it yet. (*beat*) All I knew was that he'd looked at me, once, in the rain, like I was a person. (*beat*) And that being looked at was the one thing, in my whole family, I was never, ever meant to be.

The two warm voices, going away up the wet street. The thin hum under. The clock.

NARRATOR: Remember the receipt. The little folded square he made of it. (*beat*) Because by the end of it, I was the only person left alive who'd ever noticed it at all.

SNAP to silence. Rain only. Out.

Episode 2: Reps

Three streams. **Bold** is sound. (*SURFACE*) is spoken in the room. (*CHORD*) is the channel — layered, roomless, cold, one voice short. (*HIM*) is Daniel's interior; his feeling for Wren is the one thread no *CHORD* line ever precedes. *NARRATOR* is Wren, years later, reconstructing; she cannot hear the *CHORD*. See the *README*.

A house at evening. The same old timber, the same unhurried clock. A kettle coming up to the boil. Three women moving through rooms — you can hear it in the floor, the way they never collide, never call out, never need to ask where another one is. Under it: the thin layered hum, the hole in it. A door; a coat hung; the kettle clicks off.

NARRATOR (close): He came on the Sunday. I want to tell you my family lived somewhere grand, somewhere with a name, but it was just a house — too big for us, the way every house we ever had was a little too big and a little too far from the next one. (*beat*) We moved a lot. More than anyone I've ever met since. I used to think we were unlucky with landlords. (*a small dry beat*) There was a fireplace in that house and we never once lit it. My mother kept the matches in a drawer in the kitchen, at the back, behind things, the way other people keep a thing they're frightened of where they won't come across it by accident.

A knock. A real knock, on real wood. Then warmth pouring out — LISS's voice, bright at the door.

LISS (SURFACE — delighted): You came! You actually came, Mum said you'd lose your nerve —

DANIEL (SURFACE — laughing, off the back foot, charmed): I — no, I'm — these are for you. Both of you. All — however many of you there —

VALA (SURFACE — from deeper in the house, mild): Three. There are three of us. (*the smallest pause — a thing she has had to start saying differently and is getting used to*) There are three of us, dear, come in out of the cold.

CHORD (cold, layered, roomless; and in the gap where the third voice should be, nothing — the count is off and the channel notes it without feeling it): Three. (*flat*) The number is wrong. Proceed as if it is not. He must find a whole house. A house missing a voice asks to be looked at. We do not get looked at.

DANIEL (HIM — a flicker of cold he can't account for, then gone): ... why have I got a chill on me. (*beat*) The heating's on, the place is warm, and there's a draught coming off it like a window's open somewhere I can't see. (*he shrugs it off, straight into gratitude*) Big old house. Doesn't matter. (*warmer*) I've not been this glad to be let in anywhere in years.

NARRATOR (over it): I carried the flowers to the kitchen. That was a job I could do.

The table. Warm clatter — cups, a tin opened, biscuits. **LISS and DANIEL close; their voices easy, the rhythm of two people getting on. WREN further off — the scrape of her chair is a half-second behind everyone else's, always.**

LISS (*SURFACE — warm, leaning in, that bright attention*): — no, but tell me the actual thing, not the version you tell at parties. The friend who bailed. You do that, don't you, you make everything into the funny short version so nobody has to —

DANIEL (*SURFACE — caught out, pleased to be caught*): God. Yeah. (*beat*) Okay. The actual thing.

CHORD: She has him opening. Warm the words; keep nothing under them. (*precise, like a hand on a dial*) Attend to him completely. Mean none of it. This is the skill. Run it warm. Do not let it catch.

NARRATOR (*present-day, quiet*): My sister had a gift I used to envy so badly it kept me up at night. She could give you her *whole* face. Every bit of her, turned on you like a lamp. (*beat*) It took me half my life to work out what was wrong with the way she did it, and when I finally did, I couldn't have told you in words. It was just — (*searching*) — you know how a hotel room is warm? The heating's on, it's a perfectly warm room, and you still wouldn't call it cosy, because nobody lives there. (*beat*) She was a warm room nobody lived in. And men walked into her like coming in from the rain.

LISS (*SURFACE — soft, perfectly timed*): That's so sad. (*beat*) No — I mean it. That's really sad, Daniel.

DANIEL (*HIM — and the bloom comes a beat late, and he owns it completely*): ...she *gets* it. She actually — nobody's ever just said *that's sad*, nobody just lets it be sad, they all try to fix it or top it. (*wondering*) I could fall for someone who just lets a thing be sad.

NARRATOR: He didn't know he'd been handed the feeling. Neither did I, then. I just thought: lucky her. Lucky him. (*beat*) I brought the tea over and nobody looked up, and I went back for the milk nobody had asked for, so I'd have a reason to stand.

A small thing now — and the listener must catch that no CHORD line precedes it. DANIEL, mid-sentence to Liss, glances off — toward where Wren is standing with the milk.

DANIEL (*SURFACE — to the room, to Wren really*): Sorry — Wren, is it? You've barely — come and sit, you're hovering like you're on shift.

CHORD (*cold; a small recalculation*): He turns to the sister. Unhelpful. (*beat*) Draw him back. Have the daughter laugh.

LISS (*SURFACE — laughing, reclaiming*): Oh, ignore her, she's happiest hovering, aren't you — Daniel, tell me about the brother, you said there was a brother —

And here — the resistance, and the patience. DANIEL lets himself be drawn back. But.

DANIEL (*HIM — under it, true, un-planted*): ...she does look like she's on shift, though. In her own kitchen. Who taught her to stand like that. (*a beat*) Like she's waiting to be told she can sit down.

CHORD: He returns. (*flat — no alarm; the chord does not panic; the chord waits*) He returns slowly. Note it. The sister holds his eye a half-beat past the others. We will not seat them together again tonight.

NARRATOR (*present-day, and it lands quietly on her*): You hear that? (*beat*) He noticed how I stood. (*a small broken sound that isn't quite a laugh*) I'd have given a finger, then, to know a man had spent one second on how I stood in a kitchen. (*beat*) I'd have told you it couldn't have happened. That nobody clocks the furniture. (*very quiet*) I have spent years deciding whether I made that up. I've decided both ways. Tonight I've decided it was real. Ask me tomorrow.

The acoustic opens — a different memory pushing in. Daylight. A street, traffic, a supermarket's automatic doors. WREN, present in the past, mid-errand. And then a voice she half-knows — a man's, but wrong. Flattened. The colour turned down out of it, like a photograph left in a window.

NARRATOR (*quiet, present-day*): I told you I'd see them again. After. (*beat*) This is the one I could never put back to sleep.

MAN (*SURFACE — and his voice should be audibly diminished*)* the words intact, the life under them drained; warm content, no warmth)* — sorry, do I — you look so — have we —

WREN (*SURFACE — careful, kind, not placing him yet*): I think maybe? Sorry. I'm terrible with —

MAN (*SURFACE, that flat patient drift*): No, it's — you've got one of those faces. (*beat*) I don't really — I've not been sleeping great. Since. (*beat*) Since I don't know when, actually. Funny. You lose track.

NARRATOR (*over it, and you can hear her not-letting-herself*): I knew him. I'd brought him home. Not that spring — the spring before, maybe. He'd been — I remembered him *loud*. Full of opinions about football and his ex-wife and a band he'd seen in '99. (*beat*) And here he was, in the cereal aisle, and somebody had turned him *down*. Like a radio in another room. All the words still there. No song in them.

MAN (*SURFACE*): Anyway. (*beat*) You take care. (*beat*) Whoever you are.

His footsteps go. The automatic doors. WREN, not moving.

NARRATOR: I stood there a long time. (*beat*) And I want you to watch what I did next, because it's the whole of me, it's the thing I did my entire life until it killed the people I loved. (*beat*) I thought: *poor man. Life does that to people.* And I picked up my shopping. (*beat*) There was a question, right there, with its hand up. I could feel it. The question was: *every man you have ever brought to that house — where are they now? What do they sound like now?* (*beat*) And something in me reached out, very gently, the way you'd settle a child, and put the question back to sleep. (*beat*) I called that being good. I'd been trained to call it being good. The not-asking. I was so, so good at it.

CHORD (*cold, from memory, certain*): The drained do not return to us. They have nothing left to give and no reason to come. (*flat*) This is tidy. We prefer tidy. (*beat*) The sister sees one in the street and grieves him a little and forgets. She is built to forget the thing she is built to do. It is why she is bearable to keep.

NARRATOR (*very quiet*): I didn't hear that. (*beat*) But I lived it. Word for word.

Back to the house. Night now. Daniel gone home — a car, a door, the gravel. The three women alone. The thin hum, the hole in it. Vala in the kitchen; Liss somewhere above; the floor telling us where everyone is. And here the CHORD is at its coldest and clearest, because there is no man to perform for — this is the house talking to itself.

CHORD (*layered, roomless, decided*): The man is good. (*beat*) Not for the table. (*a weight comes into it — the nearest the channel gets to gravity*) This one is for the line.

NARRATOR (*over it; she is climbing the stairs in the memory, half-hearing the house go still beneath her*): I came in from putting the cups away and the house had done the thing again. Gone still. That held-breath stillness. (*beat*) My mother was standing in the kitchen doorway — she'd started doing that since the funeral, standing in doorways — and she looked at me, and for once she smiled, and said —

VALA (*SURFACE — warm, and it is the warmest she has been; the curdled-mother register, real love bent into ownership*): You did well, love. You brought us a good one. (*beat*) You see? You're not no use. When you're useful you're so —

She doesn't finish it. She doesn't have to.

NARRATOR (*present-day, and this is the wound the whole show turns on*): *You're not no use.* (*beat*) You'd have to have grown up the way I grew up to know what that sentence does to a body. I felt it go all the way down. I'd have brought her a hundred men to hear the back half of it. (*beat*) The thing is — and I need you to hold both of these at once, because I can't seem to put them down — the thing is, she *meant* it. That's not a monster talking. That's my mother, who loved me, telling me I'd been good. (*beat*) It was the kindest she'd been to me in a year. (*beat*) And I floated up those stairs on it like a girl who'd been told she was pretty.

CHORD: The sister is useful and therefore content. (*flat*) Contentment in the sister is a maintenance state. Maintain it. (*beat*) For the line, the budding will be soon. The mother grieves; the grief makes her quick; quick is acceptable. The daughter is ripe. (*beat*) It is time.

The hum. The hole in it. The clock.

NARRATOR: I lay in bed that night happier than I'd been since before the funeral. *(beat)* A man had noticed how I stood. My mother had said I wasn't no use. *(beat)* And somewhere under the floor of my own house, in the one room I was never allowed into, in the one language I was born without — it had been decided what Daniel was for. *(beat)* He was for the line. *(beat)* I didn't know the words. I want that understood. I didn't have the words. *(very quiet)* But I'd felt the house go still like that before, every time, and every time, a few weeks later, there'd be one fewer place set at the table, and a man somewhere in a supermarket with the colour turned down out of him, saying *whoever you are* to a girl he used to know loud.

Silence opening under the words.

NARRATOR: I knew. *(beat)* The way you know a thing you've decided your whole life not to know. *(beat)* I'd have told you, that night, that I didn't have the first idea. *(beat)* And I'd have been lying, the way I lied to myself — gently, lovingly, the way you settle a child — every single day of my life.

SNAP to silence. The clock, alone, three beats. Out.

Episode 3: The Hard Week

Three streams. **Bold** is sound. (*SURFACE*) spoken in the room. (*CHORD*) the channel — layered, roomless, cold, one voice short. (*HIM*) Daniel's interior; his feeling for Wren is never preceded by a *CHORD* line. *NARRATOR* is Wren, reconstructing; she cannot hear the *CHORD*. See the *README*.

The house, a week on. It has filled out a little — there is a man in it now, on and off, and you can hear how a house changes when someone is being made welcome: more chairs moved, a second pot of coffee, music low. But under the welcome, the thin layered hum, and the hole in it, unchanged. The amputation does not heal. It only gets dressed for company.

NARRATOR (close): He started coming most days. (*beat*) That's fast, I know. I thought so too, at the time — I had a whole speech ready about how he shouldn't, how it was too quick, how he barely knew us. I never gave it. (*a small dry beat*) You don't slow a thing down when the slowing-down would mean admitting you can see where it's going.

Daniel and Liss, somewhere in the house, laughing — that easy, established rhythm now.

NARRATOR: And he was *happy*. That's the part I can't get round, even now. I'd watch him come up the path with his shoulders down out of his ears for once, this man who folded his receipts to nothing, and he'd be — light. Whatever we were doing to him, it didn't feel to him like being done to. It felt like being chosen. (*beat*) I knew that feeling. I lived for that feeling. (*beat*) I should have known sooner what it cost. I, of all people, should have known what it costs to feel chosen by us.

A room with the two of them — Liss and Daniel, close, intimate, the courtship at its warmest. Wine. Rain returning at the window. And underneath, for the first time, we hear the suppression as a live thing: the *CHORD* working Liss like a hand on a dial, and a flicker where it almost slips.

DANIEL (HIM — settling into the warmth, and under it a thread he can't place): ... God, I'm tired. (*beat*) I come up that path light as anything and drive home wrung right out. Sleep ten hours and wake like I've not slept at all. (*he smiles it off*) Happy-tired. That's a thing, though, isn't it. I'd forgotten what it is to have something worth being worn out for.

LISS (SURFACE — low, warm, the lamp turned full on him): Stay tonight. (*beat*) I'm not being — I just don't want the day to be over. Is that mad.

DANIEL (SURFACE — undone, gentle): It's not mad. (*beat*) God. No.

CHORD (cold, layered, roomless; precise, supervisory): Run it warm. (*beat*) Bring the breath up. Let the body answer. (*a fraction sharper*) The body answers — hold the latch down. Hold it. The warmth is the tool. The warmth is not *yours*. You do not keep what you spend.

A pause. And then — small, almost nothing, a half-second where *LISS*'s breath catches in a way that isn't performance. The *CHORD* reacts — the nearest it comes to alarm: not louder, *faster*, clamping.

CHORD (*quick, hard*): — there. (*flat, immediate*) There. It reaches. Down. (*a beat, then cold control restored*) Down. (*slower now*) The daughter is under-rehearsed. The eldest would have caught that sooner. (*the gap where Edda is not — a half-beat of nothing*) The eldest is not here to catch it. We are short, and the daughter is green, and we proceed anyway, because the mother will not wait. Note the risk. Continue.

NARRATOR (*present-day, over it, and she is guessing into the room she was shut out of*): I wasn't in the room for that. (*beat*) I'm imagining it — I want to be honest that I'm imagining it, because the temptation, when you've had thirty years, is to pretend you saw everything. I didn't see this. (*beat*) But I heard, through the wall, my sister's breath do a thing. (*beat*) One sound. Like a swimmer who thinks, for half a length, that they might not make the far side. And then nothing — she made it, she always made it — and the wine went on, and the low laughing. (*beat*) I lay in the dark next door and I thought: *she's so easy with people. Everything's so easy for her.* (*very quiet*) I'd have screamed if I'd known what that one caught breath was. (*beat*) It was the first finger-hold of the thing that was going to take her. And I lay there and envied it.

Morning. Kitchen. The ordinary clatter. And now a true small scene between WREN and DANIEL — and the listener must hear: nothing is planted. The CHORD is silent through this. This is the seam-free thread, the one real thing.

DANIEL (*SURFACE — easy, drying a cup he wasn't asked to dry*): She's still asleep. Your mum's — I don't actually know where your mum goes. She's like weather. She's just suddenly in a room.

WREN (*SURFACE — careful, a little startled to be spoken to plainly*): You get used to it.

DANIEL (*SURFACE*): Do you, though. (*beat — gentle, not prying*) You don't seem used to anything in this house. You seem like a guest who's been here longest.

A beat. Water running. WREN doesn't answer that.

DANIEL (*HIM — quiet, true, un-planted, and the listener can hear it is the real one*): ...don't push it. She'll bolt. (*beat*) She's lovely, the sister. She's the loveliest one and she doesn't know it and somebody's seen to it that she'll never find out. (*beat*) It makes me — I don't know what it makes me. Sad. Sad in a way that wants to do something about it.

WREN (*SURFACE — deflecting, drying her hands*): You're good at this. The dishes. (*beat*) Most men who come here don't —

DANIEL (*SURFACE — light, but he means it*): Most men who come here are here for your sister. (*beat*) I came back for your sister. (*beat*) But I keep ending up in the kitchen with you.

Silence. The tap, off. Rain.

NARRATOR (*present-day, and it costs her everything to say it level*): There it is again. (*beat*) And here's what I did with it, because I want you to see the machine I was, the machine they made me — I heard *I keep ending up in the kitchen with you*, and I translated it, instantly, the way you translate a language you think in, into: *he feels sorry for me.* (*beat*) That's not modesty. I want to be clear it isn't modesty, it isn't even sadness, really. It's a — a fact-checker. There's a thing in me, they put it there, that takes any warmth pointed my way and runs it through a filter that only ever returns one of two answers: *they want something*, or *they've made a mistake.* (*beat*) Warmth toward me is an error. The system corrects it. (*beat*) So a man stood in my kitchen and told me the truest thing anyone had said to me in years, and I filed it under *mistake*, and dried my hands, and went to wake my sister so he could go and be with the person he'd come for. (*beat*) I built the morning around getting myself out of that kitchen. (*very quiet*) I have wondered, since, what he heard in that. Whether he learned, that morning, that there was no point. I taught men there was no point in me. I was so good at it I taught the only one who meant it.

Later. WREN low — you can hear it in her, the supermarket man still on her, the grief, the tiredness. VALA finds her. And this is the feeding: rendered as the tenderest thing in the episode, an embrace, and the listener must hear Wren's voice go greyer coming out of it.

VALA (*SURFACE — warm, real, a mother*): Oh, look at you. (*beat*) Come here. Come here to me. You've gone all — you get like this, you always have, since you were tiny. Come here.

An embrace. Real, in the room — the rustle of it, a hand on hair. It should sound like exactly what Wren has wanted her whole life. And under it, the CHORD, cold, doing something else entirely.

CHORD (*low, roomless, almost gentle in its coldness — which is the worst of it*): The sister is full of self. She is always a little full of self; it is what she is; it is why she tires us and why we keep her. (*beat*) She is low and soft now. Take a little. (*beat*) Gently. She mistakes it for love and is soothed by it; this is convenient; it is how she has always been kept calm. (*a beat*) Never finish her. She is not prey. (*flat*) She is the pantry we do not empty.

VALA (*SURFACE — still holding her, and this is real, this is the curdle, the warmth that was true before the we ate it*): You were such a serious little thing. (*beat*) Before you — (*she stops; something in her reaches for a memory and the we closes over it*) — you used to hold my finger so hard. Both hands. Like you'd fall off the world. (*beat*) I used to —

She doesn't finish. Something in her changes register — the warmth doesn't vanish but it sets, like a jelly, into something that owns rather than holds.

VALA (*SURFACE — and now it is ownership wearing the coat of love*): There. (*beat*) You're mine, aren't you. You've always been mine. My funny, useful girl. (*beat*) Now. Dry your face. We've a man to think about.

The embrace ends. WREN's voice, when it comes, is greyer. The colour a notch down.

NARRATOR (*and the timbre is flatter than before — the listener should feel it*): I always felt worse after she held me. (*beat*) I never told anyone that, because what kind of person feels worse after their mother holds them? (*beat*) I decided it was me. Obviously I decided it was me. I decided I was the kind of broken that can't even take comfort right — that takes a kindness and turns it grey. (*beat*) I'd come away from her arms tired to my bones and ashamed of being tired, and I'd think: *she gives and gives to me and look what I do with it.* (*a long beat*) I had it exactly backwards. (*very quiet*) But do you want to know the thing I can't say to anyone, the thing that makes me no better than any of them — (*beat*) — I would still go to her. (*beat*) Right now. If she walked in. If she opened her arms and said *come here to me* in that voice, I would cross the room, knowing — *knowing* — what it costs, knowing it takes a little each time and calls it love. I would go. (*beat*) Because for the length of the holding, I wasn't alone in here. (*beat*) And you do not know — I hope to God you never know — what you'd trade for the length of the holding.

The hum. The hole. The clock.

Evening. The whole house in motion now — but it has changed key. The held-breath stillness from before is back, and harder. Decision is in the air. DANIEL is gone for the night; the women are alone. And WREN, at the foot of the stairs, is watching her sister be worked, and the crack opens.

Through a doorway: LISS and VALA, low, and the CHORD beneath them, and DANIEL's absence in the room like a fourth presence being discussed.

CHORD (*cold, decided, the gravity from last episode now full*): The man is ready. He comes without being called now; he does our work for us; we did not plant the last of it and it served us regardless. (*flat*) This is what *ready* is. (*beat*) The mother will not wait for more rehearsal. The eldest is three weeks in the ground and the house is thin and the hunger is up and waiting is a luxury for a whole chord, not an amputated one. (*beat*) Soon. The budding will be soon.

NARRATOR (*over it, at the foot of the stairs, and the crack comes here*): I couldn't hear that. (*beat*) What I could see was my sister, through the door, with the face she put on for men — that whole, given, lamp-lit face — except there was no man there. She was practising it on the empty chair where he'd sat. (*beat*) And

my mother watching her do it, the way you'd watch a daughter try on a dress. *(beat)* And I thought — I didn't mean to think it, it just arrived — I thought: *he believes that face. He thinks all of that is for him. He thinks he's wanted.* *(beat)* And then, before I could stop it: *I know that feeling.* *(beat)* I know exactly that feeling.

A silence. The hum under it.

NARRATOR *(slow, and you can hear the thought trying to complete itself)*: And then it kept going, the thought, on its own, downhill, somewhere I'd never let a thought go before. It went: *if his being wanted isn't real — if she's practising it on a chair — then what I do, out there, in the cafés, with nothing but talk — (beat) — the listening, the going-quiet- for-them, the — (beat) — that's the same — (beat) — I do the same*

And here, the guillotine: not a sound from outside but inside her — a clean, bright drop of guilt that she experiences as conscience, as goodness, as a return to herself.

NARRATOR *(the thought cut off cleanly, the relief audible and terrible)*: — and then the floor came back. The way it always did. A clean warm flood of — I called it conscience. *(beat)* It felt exactly like being a good person again. It felt like catching myself being ungrateful, being suspicious, being *that rot they could never cut out of me* — thinking ill of my family, of my mother who held me, of my sister who'd never done a thing but be born right. *(beat)* The relief of it. God, the relief. To stop the thought and feel *good* for stopping it. *(beat)* I went up to bed ashamed of myself for the thing I'd almost let myself understand. *(very quiet)* That's the cruelest piece of machinery they ever built in me. Not that I couldn't see it. That every time I got close, seeing it felt like sinning, and *looking away* felt like grace.

The stairs. WREN climbing. And VALA's voice, from a doorway below, stopping her — and this is the dread-button: the order to close the lure, and Wren's first, wordless inability to say yes to it.

VALA *(SURFACE — mild, loving, ordinary as asking her to fetch milk)*: Wren, love. Before you go up. *(beat)* The man. *(beat)* It's time you brought him all the way in. Properly. This weekend. *(beat)* You started it; you should finish it. *(warm)* You're so good at the finishing.

A pause. The clock. The hum. WREN, on the stairs, not turning round.

NARRATOR *(present-day, very quiet)*: *Bring him all the way in.* *(beat)* I'd heard it a hundred times, about a hundred men, and a hundred times I'd said *yes, Mum*, and meant it, and done it, and felt useful, and slept fine. *(beat)* And I stood on those stairs with my hand on the rail and my mouth open to say *yes, Mum* — *(beat)* — and nothing came out. *(beat)* Nothing came out.

The held breath of the whole house. Hold it.

NARRATOR: I told her I would. *(beat)* In the end. A second too late, and in a voice that came out wrong, and I covered it with a cough and a *night, Mum*, and went up. *(beat)* But for one second on those stairs, for the first time in my whole life, my family asked me to do the only thing I was good for — *(beat)* — and my body said no before I had any idea why.

SNAP to silence. The clock. The hum. The hole in it, loud. Out.

Episode 4: Step Back

Three streams. **Bold** is sound. (*SURFACE*) spoken in the room. (*CHORD*) the channel — layered, roomless, cold, one voice short. (*HIM*) Daniel's interior; his feeling for Wren is never preceded by a *CHORD* line. *NARRATOR* is Wren, reconstructing; she cannot hear the *CHORD*. See the *README*.

The house, mid-week. Quiet. Rain off, for once — a wet, dripping after-rain, gutters ticking. The thin hum, the hole. And something new in the quality of the quiet: a waiting. The house is waiting for Wren to do a thing, and she has not done it.

NARRATOR (close, and there is a tightness in her tonight): I want to tell you I had a plan. (beat) People always think there must have been a plan — that I'd worked something out, that I was being brave. (a dry, unhappy beat) There was no plan. There was just a weekend my mother had named, and a thing I was supposed to do before it, and every day I didn't do it, and a reason each day for why I hadn't. (beat) The reasons were good. That's the worst of it. The reasons were *excellent*.

Kitchen. *VALA*, mild, expectant. *WREN*, busy with something that doesn't need doing — the sound of a person manufacturing occupation.

VALA (*SURFACE* — light, but the lightness has a floor under it): Is he coming Saturday, then.

WREN (*SURFACE* — too quick, too smooth, the procurer's competence turned to a new use): I wouldn't push Saturday. (beat) He's got a thing — work thing, his brother's down — and you know what he's like, he spooks, you push him and he goes quiet for a week. (beat) Let him come to it. He always comes to it. Better he thinks it's his idea.

CHORD (cold, layered, roomless; listening to the sister the way you listen to a tool for the note that means it is about to break): The sister manages the man. (beat) The reasons are sound. (a beat — and here the chord does the thing it does best, which is wait and weigh) The reasons are sound and there are too many of them. (flat) She has never needed reasons before. She does the work and reports it done. Reasons are new. (beat) Note it.

NARRATOR (over it): And it was true, all of it. He did have a brother down that weekend. He did spook. (beat) That's the trick I'd never understood I was doing, the trick I'd done to men my whole life and was now, for the first time, doing *for* one — you don't lie. You never lie. You find the true thing that happens to point the way you need, and you hold it up, and you let it do the lying. (beat) I held up every true small reason I could find, that week, so that not one of them had to stand next to the actual reason, which I could not have said out loud if you'd held me under water. (beat) The actual reason was: I could not hand him over. (beat) I didn't know that was the reason. I want to be exact. I knew I kept not doing it. I did not know why, the way you don't know why you keep not opening a letter.

A scene with *DANIEL* — the deepest yet, and the cruelest, because it is real and she is stalling his delivery even as it happens. A pub, maybe, or a walk; the two of them; *LISS* not here. The

CHORD silent throughout — this thread is un-worked, and the listener must feel the betrayal forming under the realness.

DANIEL (*SURFACE — easier with her than with anyone, which is the horror*): Can I tell you a thing I haven't told her. (*beat*) Liss. (*beat*) Don't — it's not bad, it's just —

WREN (*SURFACE — and you can hear her brace, scanning his tone for the verdict*): You don't have to tell me things.

DANIEL (*SURFACE*): I know. That's why I want to. (*beat*) Everyone I tell things to, I'm sort of — performing the telling. You know? Even with her. *Especially*, maybe, with her — it's like she's so easy to talk to that I end up talking *well*, talking like the good version, and I come away feeling like I had a lovely time being someone slightly better than me. (*beat*) With you I just — say it. (*beat*) You're a hard person to be a better version at.

A beat. Gutters ticking. WREN says nothing.

DANIEL (*HIM — quiet, true, un-planted*): ...there it is. The face. She thinks I'm being unkind. (*beat*) How do you tell someone *you're the only one here I don't have to lie to* and have them hear it as the love it is. (*beat*) You can't, with her. Someone got there first. Someone taught her that's not a thing that gets said to her.

WREN (*SURFACE — deflecting, but gently, and it nearly cracks her*): That's not a compliment, Daniel. (*a small, real, broken laugh*) "You're hard to perform for." Put it on a card.

DANIEL (*SURFACE — and he lets her have the joke, but*): It's the best thing I've said to anyone in years. (*beat*) You'll see, one day. Or you won't, and that'll be the saddest thing about you.

NARRATOR (*present-day, level, and it nearly takes her under*): He trusted me. (*beat*) That's what I have to make you understand, because it's the engine of the whole thing, it's the sin I can't ever set down. The reason the lure worked — the reason it always worked, the reason I was good at it — was that I was the realest thing in that family. The one who actually listened. The one who actually saw you. (*beat*) So he did the sanest thing a person could do. He trusted the realest one. (*beat*) He told the truth to the only honest person in the house. (*beat*) And the only honest person in the house was the bait. (*a long beat*) I made him trust a real person so I could hand him to people who weren't. (*very quiet*) I didn't decide to. That's not an excuse, it's worse than an excuse — I'd been built to do it without deciding, the way your heart doesn't decide to beat. By the time I loved him, the betrayal was already most of the way done. I'd done the worst of it being kind.

DANIEL (*HIM — easy, half to himself, the warmth blurring the edges of things*): ...how long have I even been coming here. Weeks? Feels like no time. Feels like always. (*beat*) I can't find the edges of it — the days all run warm together, one long afternoon. (*and he lets them stay blurred*) Don't count it. Good things don't like being counted.

A turn. DANIEL, lighter, changing the subject — and he asks the innocent question that triggers the flat, late, never-staged revelation. This must be thrown away, not performed.

DANIEL (*SURFACE — easy, making conversation*): So it's just you and Liss, then. (*beat*) No — I keep meaning to ask, your mum says "the girls," like there's a whole — were there more of you? Brothers?

WREN (*SURFACE — a beat too still, then smooth*): Just us. (*beat*) Just the girls.

The scene holds a half-second too long on that. Then the acoustic thins — we drop out of the pub into the bare close of WREN's narration, no room around it.

NARRATOR (*flat — and this must be the flattest she ever is, because it is the thing she was most trained not to feel*): There were brothers. (*beat*) I don't say it for effect. I say it the way I was taught to hold it, which is to say I hardly hold it at all. (*beat*) In a family like mine, a girl might be the wrong kind of girl and they'd not know for years — they kept me years before they were sure I was no use. There's a — mercy isn't the

word. A delay. You get raised a while, on the chance you'll come right. *(beat)* But a boy. *(beat)* A boy they know straight off. There's nothing to wait and see. *(beat)* So there were brothers, the way there's weather there was. Born, and then — not. *(beat)* No graves I ever found. No names I was ever given. *(beat)* I used to think — when I let myself think it, which was almost never — I used to think that I only got kept because they couldn't tell about me quickly enough. *(beat)* That I'm alive on a technicality. That if I'd been a boy, or a girl they could read faster, I'd be weather too. *(a long beat)* And the thing I could never get to line up, the thing that used to put me to sleep mid-thought like a hand over a candle — *(beat)* — the men I brought home, and the brothers who were born and then weren't — *(beat)* — my family did the exact same thing to both. The ones it used and the ones it bore. Same — *(the word costs her)* — same tidiness. *(beat)* The most loving family you ever met, and it put out its own sons like you'd put out a cigarette, and harvested strangers the same way, and never felt the difference, because to it there *was* no difference. There was the *we*, and there was everything that wasn't, and everything that wasn't was either useful or it was tidied away. *(very quiet)* Daniel asked me if there were brothers. I said *just us*. And then I went back to the thing I was good at, which was making sure he never found out what *us* meant. Until he was inside it. Until it was him.

Back to the house. The held-breath quiet, harder now. VALA has run out of patience — the grief in her gone quick and hot, the hunger up. This is the override, and it must read as love rushing, not malice deciding. The dread-button.

Footsteps — VALA's, certain, finding Wren. The CHORD beneath, decided.

CHORD *(cold, and the gravity is total now)*: Enough. *(beat)* The sister stalls. The reasons multiply. The lure no longer closes; it manages; it protects. *(flat)* A protected man is a man the sister has begun to perceive. *(beat)* We have seen this once before, long ago, in another like her, and it cost the line a generation. *(beat)* We will not wait on the dud. The daughter is green but the daughter is enough; the mother is hungry and the house is thin and three weeks is long enough to grieve. *(beat)* We move on the budding ourselves. This weekend. Whether the man is brought *all the way in* by the sister or not — he is in far enough.

VALA *(SURFACE — and there is no cruelty in it; there is a mother at the end of her patience, grieving her own mother, frightened in a way she'd never name)*: Wren. *(beat)* Sit down, love. *(beat)* I'm not cross. *(beat)* But you've been — you've not been yourself. All these reasons. *(a sigh, almost tender)* I shouldn't have put it on you. It was too much, after your gran, asking you to manage all of it. You loved your gran. *(beat)* So I'll take it from here. *(beat)* You've done your part — you brought him, you always bring them, you're so good at the bringing. *(beat)* Let your old mum do the rest. *(warm, final)* Saturday. You don't have to do a thing. You can just — be here. With your family.

A silence that is the bottom dropping out of the world, except it sounds exactly like a mother being kind.

NARRATOR *(present-day, and her voice is barely holding)*: Do you see it? *(beat)* Do you see what I did. *(beat)* I stalled to save him. That's the only true thing I can say about myself in this whole story — that once, once in my life, my body said no to handing a person over, and I listened to it for a week. *(beat)* And because I stalled — *(beat)* — because the lure faltered, because the dud got unreliable, because I cost them time they thought they didn't have — *(beat)* — they stopped waiting. *(beat)* They moved it up. They took it out of my hands and they did it *sooner*, and *faster*, and — I didn't know this then, I learned it after, I learned it in the only way you ever learn anything in that house, which is too late — *faster meant my sister wasn't ready*. *(beat)* My one mercy. *(beat)* My one good thing. *(beat)* I tried to slow it down and I am the reason it came early. *(very quiet)* If I'd been the machine they made me — if I'd just done my job, closed the lure on schedule, handed him over cold like all the others — my sister would have been readier, and the thing that happened to her might not have. *(beat)* It was my love that rushed them. *(beat)* Hold onto that, because everyone always wants the part where love saves somebody. *(beat)* This is the other story. This is the one where the first loving thing I ever did is the thing that brought the whole house down.

The held breath. The hum. The hole in it. The clock.

NARRATOR: She said *you don't have to do a thing*. *(beat)* And I didn't. *(beat)* That's the part I'll answer

for. Not that I couldn't stop it. *(beat)* That when she took it out of my hands, some terrible, trained, grateful part of me was *relieved*. *(beat)* Saturday came. And I just — was there. With my family. *(beat)* Like she said.

SNAP to silence. The clock, alone. Out.

Episode 5: The Budding

Three streams. **Bold** is sound. (*SURFACE*) spoken in the room. (*CHORD*) the channel — layered, roomless, cold, one voice short. (*HIM*) Daniel's interior; his feeling for Wren is never preceded by a *CHORD* line. *NARRATOR* is Wren, reconstructing; she cannot hear the *CHORD* — so where her narration touches it tonight, she is imagining her way into the room she was barred from. The act itself is never depicted. The horror is the cold over the tender, and what is heard from outside the door. See the *README*.

Saturday. Evening coming on. The house warmer than we have ever heard it — fire-warm, except there is no fire; lamps, wine breathing, something in the oven, music low and old. It should sound like the best night of someone's life. Under it, the thin hum, the hole. And something else now, rising as the evening settles: a low, almost-pleasant resonance in the house itself, a warmth that has nothing to do with the lamps. The house, getting ready to be whole.

NARRATOR (*close, and very careful, like someone handling something that could still cut*): I was downstairs for it. (*beat*) I need to start there, because everything I'm about to tell you about that room, I wasn't in. (*beat*) I've spent thirty years building that room out of what I heard through a floor and what I learned after and what I've made myself able, finally, to imagine. (*beat*) So when I take you up there — and I am going to take you up there, once, and then never again — you should know it's me doing it. Me, reaching into the one room I was never let into, trying to put myself beside him. (*beat*) It's the only way I have left to be beside him. (*beat*) So let me.

Earlier in the evening. The table. DANIEL, happy, a little drunk on the warmth, telling a story; LISS, the lamp full on him; VALA, mild, present. The ordinary best-night-of-his-life. The CHORD beneath, arranging.

DANIEL (*SURFACE — loose, glowing*): — and I keep thinking, all week I've been thinking, I'm going to wake up and it'll be — you know when something's too — (*he laughs at himself*) I don't trust good things. I've never trusted good things. And this is the first one in — God, I don't know how long — that I've just let myself —

LISS (*SURFACE — soft, leaning, the whole given face*): Then don't wake up. (*beat*) Stay.

CHORD (*cold, layered, roomless; the envelopment beginning — one voice to hold him, the rest to work beneath*): The daughter holds his attention and his spoken self. (*beat*) The mother takes the rest — the breath, the blood, the wanting. He will feel one field, seamless, fated. He will call it *I couldn't help myself*. There is no seam because there is no seam in us. (*flat*) Bring him up. Gently. Let it be his idea.

DANIEL (*HIM — and the bloom is almost instant now, he is so far in*): ...stay. (*beat*) Yeah. God, yes. When does a feeling like this come round again — never, it comes round never — (*a wondering, helpless joy*) I'm not going to be the idiot who walks away from the one good —

NARRATOR (*over it, present-day*): He thought he was deciding. (*beat*) That's the thing I keep — he was so happy to be deciding. You could hear it. A man choosing the best thing that ever happened to him, choosing it with his whole chest. (*beat*) And I want to be careful here, because the easy version of this, the lurid

version, is a man being dragged somewhere against his will, and that is not what this was, and the truth is so much worse than that. *(beat)* Nobody dragged him. *(beat)* He went up those stairs like a man going to his own good life. *(beat)* They didn't take his *body*. His body was a willing volunteer; his body had a wonderful time. *(beat)* What they took, he never even knew he had to guard. *(very quiet)* They used the whole of him — every true, hopeful, lonely thing in him — and the only part of the transaction he was let in on was the part where he was happy.

The stairs. Two sets of feet, unhurried. A door. And then — this is the discipline — we do not follow them in. The door closes. We stay on the landing, and what we hear is the contrast that is the entire horror: through the wood, the muffled warmth of the surface — and in our ear, close and roomless and cold, the channel, which does not stop, which is not in the room because it is in the skull, studying him while he gives himself away.

Behind the door, indistinct, warm: LISS's voice, DANIEL's voice, the human sounds of two people who are, on the surface, in love. Pitch them low, kind, ordinary. Never explicit. Let them blur into texture almost at once.

CHORD *(over it, close, cold, appraising — the violation is the distance in this voice)*: Good. *(beat)* He is generous. He gives more than is asked. Note the vitality — high, very high; this is why he was chosen; this is the best of him and it is exactly the thing we take. *(beat)* The daughter runs the cascade. Full, now — no holding back, this is the budding, not the rehearsal; she must run it to the top to conceive. *(a beat, and the first edge of strain)* Full load. *(beat)* Hold the latch. *(beat)* This is the part she did not get to practise enough. Hold it. Hold the —

DANIEL *(HIM — through it, and the listener must hold both at once: his joy, and the cold over it)*: ...she's shaking. *(tender, mistaking everything)* She's shaking, she's as gone as I am, nobody's ever — I'd do anything for her, I'd —

NARRATOR *(present-day, and this is her imagining her way in, and it is unbearable, and it is love)*: He thought her shaking was for him. *(beat)* I've made myself picture it. His whole kind heart, reading the one true thing in that room — *something is happening that's bigger than her* — and getting it exactly, catastrophically wrong. *(beat)* He made love to a wall. A warm wall, a willing wall, a wall that said his name. *(beat)* And the wall was studying him. The wall was taking notes. *(beat)* And the worst of it, the thing I can hardly — he'd have *liked* that, if he'd known the wall was paying that much attention. He was so unused to being attended to. *(beat)* They gave him the most complete attention of his life. There was no one behind it. *(very quiet)* That's the thing they do that looks the most like love and is the furthest from it. Total attention, with no one home. *(beat)* I should know. I'd been doing it to men in cafés for thirty years.

And now the strain becomes the event. The CHORD, which has clamped a flicker before (Ep3), meets the full load — and this time the clamp does not hold. The sound: the layered chord pulling tight, harder, a tension like a wire — and then, instead of the clean snap-back of the rehearsal, a *slipping*. Something catches that should not catch. Render it as the chord losing its even unison for the first time — a wobble, a voice pulling fractionally out of true.

CHORD *(tight, fast, the first time it has ever sounded anything but calm)*: — it latches. *(a beat — and now genuine alarm, cold alarm, but alarm)* It latches. The daughter — the daughter *bonds*. Pull it back. Pull her — *(the unison fraying)* — she is forming an — she is forming an attachment to the — to a *separate* — *(and the word the chord cannot bear to complete)* —

VALA *(SURFACE — through the door, and this is the first crack in the mother, a sound of pure animal wrongness, a woman feeling something inside her own body go where it must not)*: — no. *(beat)* No, no — *(barely)* — down, come down —

NARRATOR *(present-day, over the fraying, from the landing of memory)*: I was downstairs. I heard my mother make a sound I'd never heard her make. *(beat)* I thought somebody was hurt. I started up the stairs.

(beat) And the house — (searching) — you know how a room sounds when everyone in it stops at once? When a whole party hears a glass break? (beat) The whole house did that. Every floorboard. Like the building itself had flinched. (beat) I didn't have the first idea what had happened. (beat) I know now. (very quiet) I know now that what I heard, standing on the third stair with my hand on the rail, was the sound of my family beginning to die. (beat) It didn't sound like dying. It sounded like the wine going quiet. It sounded like everyone, all at once, holding their breath. (beat) But somewhere above me, in the room I was never let into, in the language I was born without — (beat) — a wall had just felt something. (beat) For the first time in longer than there have been words for time — one of them had been touched by an *outside*, and the outside had stuck, and the bonding had done the one thing bonding is *for*, the thing it does to every other mammal that has ever lived — (beat) — it had made another creature *real* to her. (beat) And in my family, a creature for whom another creature is real is not a daughter anymore. (beat) It's a wound the whole body can feel.

Aftermath. The smallest hours. The house gone strange — the warm resonance from the start of the evening guttering, like a held note losing its breath. DANIEL leaving, or being seen out — a car, gravel, in the dark. And his voice, when it comes, has begun to flatten. The colour turning down. The diminishment, audible.

DANIEL (*SURFACE — and the life is going out of the timbre even as the words stay sweet*): That was — (beat) — I don't even — I'll call you. Tomorrow. (beat) I had the best — (beat) — I had a really —

He can't quite finish the sentence. Not from emotion. From subtraction.

DANIEL (*HIM — and even his interior is quieter now, the room around it draining*): ...I should feel — (beat) — I had the best night of my — why do I feel like I left something here. (beat) Like I came in with more than I'm leaving with. (beat) That chill again. (beat) And the tiredness — not happy-tired, this time. (beat) Wrung right out. Like there's less of me than there was when I came in. (beat) It's nothing. It's just — it's late.

NARRATOR (*present-day, very quiet*): He drove off into the dark with his colours turned down, saying *I'll call you tomorrow* in a voice that already had less of him in it. (beat) I stood at the window and watched the tail-lights go and I thought — (*a terrible small beat*) — God forgive me, I thought, *there he goes, like all of them, off into the wherever*. And under that, the thought I wouldn't think: *he'll be in a supermarket one day, telling a girl she's got one of those faces*. (beat) And I put it back to sleep. One last time, I put it back to sleep. (beat) It was the last night I ever managed to.

Inside. The house in its strange new quiet. The warm resonance gone now — and in its place, the thin layered hum, but *wrong*: the unison no longer even. Something in it pulling. And then — the sound the whole of this exists for. Build a silence. Let the chord hold, frayed, trying to be a *we*. And then, out of the layered voices that have only ever produced *we* — a single voice peels loose. And as it peels, for the first time in the entire series, the faintest breath of *room* gathers around it: a self has an inside and an outside now; it has a gap; the gap is acoustic space; you are hearing the birth of a separate person as the birth of a little room.

CHORD (*frayed, trying to re-gather, cold but no longer whole*): — re-absorb. (beat) Bring the daughter back into the *we*. Smooth the seam. There has always been no seam. There will be no — bring her — (*the unison straining around a voice that will not lie flat*) — bring the daughter —

And then — out of the *we* — one voice. Alone. With the first thin halo of room around it. Small. Terrified. Human. It does not announce itself. It barely manages the word at all.

LISS (*a single voice, peeling free of the unison, faintly roomed for the first time — frightened, wondering, newborn*): ...I — (beat) — I'm —

Silence. Total. The chord does not answer. It cannot. There is an *I* in it now, and it has never had to hold one before.

NARRATOR (*close, the whole world in it*): Somewhere above me, in a language I would never hear, my sister said the first word of her life. (*beat*) One letter. (*beat*) I. (*beat*) And the family that had been one long *we* since before there were countries to flee across — (*beat*) — heard it, and had no word for what it was, because in all that time, in all those bodies, it had never once needed the word *alone*.

SNAP to silence. Hold the silence longer than is comfortable. Then — the clock. Out.

Episode 6: A Self

Three streams. **Bold** is sound. (*SURFACE*) spoken in the room. (*CHORD*) the channel — layered, roomless, cold, and now fraying: a voice keeps pulling out of true. (*HIM*) Daniel's interior, hollowing — the room around it draining. *NARRATOR* is Wren, reconstructing; she cannot hear the *CHORD*. See the *README*.

The house, the days after. Wrong in a way that has no single sound — like a piece of music played by a band that has stopped agreeing on the tempo. The thin hum is still there, but it no longer breathes as one; under it, a voice keeps lifting out and being pulled back, lifting out, pulled back. And over everything, a new quality in the rooms: a person who is grieving something she will not name, moving through a house, opening doors and finding the wrong thing behind every one.

NARRATOR (close): My sister got sick. (*beat*) That's how it looked, from where I was — from the outside, where I lived. She stopped coming down. She went off her food. She'd be fine, ordinary, herself, and then her face would do a thing — go still, and frightened, like a person who's just felt a lump that wasn't there last week. (*beat*) My mother said it was a chill. My mother said it was the wedding nerves — she'd started calling it a wedding, by then, though no one had said a word to Daniel, and Daniel had stopped calling. (*beat*) I believed her, the way I believed her about everything. A chill. Nerves. (*beat*) I brought soup up to a door that wouldn't open and I told myself it was a chill, while on the other side of it my sister was being born, in agony, against her will, into a self she'd been raised her whole life to think of as a tumour.

Behind the door. And here we go where Wren could not — into the room, into the channel — and the horror is that individuation, from the inside, is not freedom. It is a self growing in a body that has the chord's values, and meets its own selfhood with the chord's revulsion.

The *CHORD*, fraying, and within it *LISS*'s voice — flickering between *we* and *I*, gaining and losing its little halo of room.

CHORD (layered, trying to be whole, cold but frightened): Come back. (*beat*) Daughter. Come back into the we. There is no out there. There has never been an out there. The thing you feel is not real; smooth it; let it go flat; let us carry it for you —

LISS (peeling out — roomed, separate, and horrified at herself): — I can't. (*beat*) I can't give it back. (*a rising panic*) There's a — there's a *me* in here, there's an *I*, I can feel the edges of it, it has *edges*, oh God, it has an inside, why does it have an —

CHORD (clamping, smoothing): — it is a sickness. It is the sickness we have always guarded against. You are not an *I*. You are the *we*, wearing this body for a while, as the *we* has worn a hundred —

LISS (out again, and now grief, the chord's own values turned on her own self): — then cut it out. (*begging*) Cut it out of me. I don't *want* it. I never wanted to be — I don't want to be a — (*the word is the worst thing she knows*) — a *person*. People are *alone*. I can feel how alone it is in here, I can feel the walls of me, I'm in a little room and there's no one else in it and there has never in my life been no one else and I can't — (*breaking*) — make it stop. Make me us again. *Please* make me us again.

NARRATOR (*present-day, over it, and it has taken her thirty years to be able to say this*): You want me to tell you she was breaking free. (*beat*) Everyone wants that. The girl in the tower, the chains coming off. (*beat*) It wasn't that. (*beat*) I have had to learn — slowly, against everything that would have been easier to believe — that what happened to my sister felt to her exactly like a disease. Because that's what she'd been taught a self was. She had all their values and none of their company. (*beat*) She wasn't reaching for the door. (*beat*) A wall was growing up through the middle of her, and she beat her fists on it and begged the people on the other side to come and take it down, and they couldn't, because the wall was *her*, the wall was the first her there'd ever been. (*very quiet*) She was the loneliest thing that had ever lived in that house. And I'd been jealous of her. (*beat*) I'd lain in the dark and envied the very thing that was now eating her alive — the thing I'd been born already inside of, and called my defect, and apologised for, every day, for thirty years.

The phone. It rings into the strange house — an ordinary, brutal sound. WREN answers, because no one else will. And it is DANIEL, hollowed, the colour gone out of him. This must be unbearable in its flatness.

WREN (*SURFACE — careful, her heart going*): Daniel?

DANIEL (*SURFACE — flat now, the warmth a memory of warmth, the words right and the life gone*): Wren. Hi. (*beat*) Is — could I talk to Liss. (*beat*) I keep — I've been meaning to. I had this — (*he reaches for it and it isn't there*) — we had a really nice time. Didn't we. (*beat*) I think we did. I can't quite — it's been a strange couple of weeks. I'm so tired, Wren. I don't know what's the matter with me.

DANIEL (*HIM — and even the interior is dim now, the room around it nearly gone*): ... why can't I picture it. (*beat*) The best night of my life and I can't — it's like a room with the lights off. I know the furniture's there. I can't see it. (*beat*) What did I leave there. What did I —

WREN (*SURFACE — and she's lying to him, gently, the only kindness she has left, and it's the same kindness that damns him*): She's just got a chill, Daniel. (*beat*) She'll call you. (*beat*) Get some rest. You sound — get some rest.

NARRATOR (*present-day*): He didn't call again after that. (*beat*) I used to wonder if he was angry. (*beat*) He wasn't angry. There wasn't enough of him left to be angry. (*beat*) He just — faded out of it, the way they all faded, off into a life with the colour turned down. (*beat*) And here is the thing I heard in his voice on that phone — the thing that finally, finally did it — (*beat*) — he sounded *like me*. (*beat*) That flat, tired, can't-quite-feel-the-good-thing, what's-the-matter-with-me — (*beat*) — that was my voice. That had always been my voice. (*very quiet*) I'd spent my life delivering men to be made into the thing I already was. (*beat*) And I'd called it the family business. And I'd been proud when I was good at it.

And here it lands. No outside sound for this — it happens inside her, on the stairs, in the hall, wherever she is when the floor finally goes. The guillotine that dropped a hundred times does not drop. The thought completes.

NARRATOR (*slow, and the whole architecture of her life coming down a beam at a time*): It came all at once and it came in the wrong order, the way the truth does when you've held it under for thirty years. (*beat*) It went: *the men go nowhere because I send them nowhere*. (*beat*) It went: *I do the thing my mother does — I make a person feel chosen so that something can be taken from them — I just do it by hand, because I never had the —* (*beat*) — *because I'm the one who can't*. (*beat*) It went: *I am not the failed one in a family of the whole. I am one of them. I learned it from them. I have been one of them all along*. (*a long, terrible beat*) And then — and this is the part I'd kept the deepest, this is the one the guillotine was really for — (*beat*) it went: *and the reason I am one of them, the reason I could ever do it at all — the talking, the listening, the going-quiet-for-them — is the one thing in me that was never theirs*. (*beat*) *They taught me to use it. But they didn't put it there*. (*beat*) *They can't do it. Not one of them can do what I do in a café with nothing but talk, because to do it you have to be able to —* (*she can barely*) — *you have to be able to actually see the person. And they can't. They never could. That's the whole —* (*beat*) — *I can see people. I'm the only one of us who can see people. And they took the one thing I had that they didn't, and they bent it into a hook, and*

they hung men on it, and they told me it was the only useful thing about me, and I believed them, because being useful was the only — (she stops; she can't; and then, very small) — oh. (beat) Oh, no. (beat) Oh, no, I'm not the broken one. (beat) I was never the broken one.

A silence. The fraying hum, under. A voice in it, lifting out, pulled back.

NARRATOR (*barely*): And do you know what I felt, when it finally landed — the truth I'd run from my whole life, the truth that should have set me free? (*beat*) I felt sick. I felt *ashamed*. (*beat*) Because the floor that dropped wasn't *they were wrong about me*. (*beat*) The floor that dropped was *they were right that there's something different in me — and they spent my whole life turning the best thing I had into the worst thing I did*. (*beat*) There's no liberation in that. There's no walking free. (*beat*) The verdict was correct. (*beat*) I really was the one who couldn't merge. (*beat*) It's just that the thing I couldn't do — that's the thing that means I can love. (*beat*) And I found that out the same week I worked out I'd spent my whole life using it to feed people to a thing that can't.

The house comes apart further. Above, LISS — the sound now genuinely frightening: a self trying to hold itself together and the chord trying to dissolve it, in the same body, a tug-of-war with no winner possible. And VALA — breaking. Not into rage. Into something worse: a mother feeling a part of her own body die, who does not have the concept of “daughter as separate person” to make sense of grief, and so experiences it as her own death, beginning.

VALA (*SURFACE — and the grandmotherly mildness is gone; this is Lear on the heath, a love so total it cannot tell itself from the beloved*): Stop it. (*beat*) Stop it, stop *doing* this to us — you're tearing — I can feel you tearing and it's *me*, don't you understand, it's not *you*, there's no *you*, you're tearing *me* — (*a sound of pure incomprehension and pure love*) — give it *back*, give yourself back, come *home* —

And then — VALA stops. Because she has turned, in the hall, and seen WREN. And something in her, in extremity, perceives — for the first time in thirty years — that the dud has edges too. That there is, and has always been, an *I* standing in her hallway. The disease, in the one she'd kept and called family and never once seen. This is the dread-button: recognition arriving the wrong way round.

VALA (*SURFACE — quiet now, a terrible quiet, looking at Wren as if at a stranger who has been in her house for thirty years*): ...you. (*beat*) You've got one too. (*beat*) Haven't you. (*beat*) You've had one the whole time. (*a breath, and the whole long misunderstanding of Wren's life turning over in it*) I used to think — when you were small — I used to think we could melt it out of you, if we just loved you enough, if we held you enough — (*beat*) — and you'd come right, you'd come in, you'd be *us*. (*beat*) And you never did. (*beat*) And I stopped trying. (*very quiet, and it is the cruelest tender thing anyone says in the whole play*) I'm sorry, love. (*beat*) I'm sorry we couldn't fix you.

Silence. Above, Liss, flickering, in and out, in and out.

NARRATOR (*present-day, and it is a wound and a key at once*): I'm sorry we couldn't fix you. (*beat*) She meant it kindly. (*beat*) That's the thing I need you to hold, the thing the whole story is — she has never once, in my whole life, been unkind to me. She loved me. (*beat*) She just loved me the only way the thing inside her could: as a part of itself that wouldn't heal. (*beat*) And in that hallway, with my sister coming apart upstairs and Daniel fading out somewhere down a road none of us would ever drive again, my mother looked at me — *really* looked, for the first time in thirty years — (*beat*) — and what she saw, the thing she finally recognised, was the disease. (*beat*) She finally saw me. (*beat*) And she was sorry. Because to her, seeing me was the same as seeing a tumour she should have caught earlier. (*very quiet*) I had wanted, my whole life, for my mother to see me. (*beat*) And she did. (*beat*) And it turned out that in my family, to be *seen* and to be *grieved as a thing that went wrong* were the same sentence. There's no other kind of being-seen in there. (*beat*) That's the room I'd spent my life trying to get into. (*beat*) That's what was on the other side of the door.

Above, the sound peaks — LISS, no longer able to be a *we*, not yet able to bear being an *I*,

makes a sound that is past words: a person drowning in the air. The chord cannot hold her and cannot let her go. And WREN, in the hall, does the thing she has never done in her life — the thing the whole story has been walking toward.

NARRATOR (*close, and steadier now, because something in her has been decided below the level of deciding*): And I went up the stairs. (*beat*) You have to understand what that was. (*beat*) There was a room in that house I had never been let into. Not once. Not in thirty years. (*beat*) The room where they were *we*. The room where the language was. The room I'd stood outside of my whole life with my ear against the door, trying to belong to a sound I'd been born without. (*beat*) And my sister was in it now, alone for the first time in the history of our line, making the sound of a creature who has just learned what alone is. (*beat*) And not one of the others could go to her. (*beat*) You can't reach across a gap you've never had. (*beat*) The mother couldn't go in. The mother could only call her *home*, call her back into the *we*, call her into the thing that was killing her. (*beat*) There was exactly one person in that whole house — in that whole long line, stretching back past every fire we'd ever run from — who knew how to walk toward someone who is alone. (*beat*) Because I'd been alone my entire life. (*beat*) I was the only one who knew the way in.

Her hand on the door. The forbidden door. The handle.

NARRATOR (*very quiet*): So I put my hand on the door of the room I was never allowed into. (*beat*) And for the first time in my life — (*beat*) — I went in.

SNAP to silence. Above, faintly, a single roomed voice, frightened, alone. Hold. Out.

Episode 7: Across the Gap

Three streams. **Bold** is sound. (*SURFACE*) spoken in the room. (*CHORD*) the channel — layered, roomless, dying: down to two voices fraying around the loss of a third, and about to lose a fourth. (*HIM*) Daniel's interior, reconstructed — the room around it gone. *NARRATOR* is Wren, reconstructing, which is to say: finally perceiving them all as real, too late. She cannot hear the *CHORD*. The listener hears everything. See the *README*. This is the end.

The forbidden room. The door opening — old hinges, a sound Wren has never made before. And then, inside: it is just a room. That is the first horror of it. After thirty years outside this door, it is an ordinary bedroom, lamplight, a window, a bed. The thing that made it forbidden was never in the walls. It was in the language, and the language is coming apart.

The *CHORD*, fraying — two voices now where there were three, and within them *LISS*, peeling in and out, drowning in air. And under everything, threaded all the way down, the hum, and its hole.

NARRATOR (*close, very quiet*): I'd built that room a thousand ways in thirty years of standing outside it. (*beat*) It was always grander, in my head. A throne room. A hearth. Somewhere you'd have to be worthy to stand. (*beat*) It was a bedroom. (*beat*) My sister was on the floor against the side of the bed with her arms around her own knees, making a sound I will hear for the rest of my life, and my mother was standing over her with her hands out, not touching her, the way you'd hold your hands out toward a fire you can't put out. (*beat*) And none of them could go to her. (*beat*) That was the thing I finally understood, standing in the doorway of the room I was never allowed in. (*beat*) They couldn't reach her. (*beat*) They'd never had to learn how. You don't learn to cross a gap when you've never had one.

VALA, over *Liss*, calling her — and this is the chord trying, desperately, lovingly, to do the only thing it knows: to dissolve the self, to bring the daughter home into the we.

VALA (*SURFACE* — *Lear, all of it love, none of it any use*): Come back to us. (*beat*) You don't have to feel this. Let it go flat. Let us carry it — that's what we're *for*, we carry each other, you've never had to be alone, not once, not in your whole — (*breaking*) — let go, my love, just let *go* of it —

LISS (*peeling out, roomed, terrified, and furious** with the terror of the newly-born):* — I *can't*, don't you understand I *can't*, it won't — (*a sob*) — you keep telling me to come home and there's no — when I reach for home there's just *me*, it's *me* all the way down now, I'm the only one in here —

CHORD (*the two voices smoothing, clamping, and failing*): — there is no *me*. Smooth it. The seam is not real. There has never been a seam —

NARRATOR (*over it, present-day*): My mother was trying to save her the only way she had. (*beat*) And the way she had was the thing that was killing her. (*beat*) *Come home. Let go. Stop being a self.* (*beat*) You'd say that to a drowning girl: *stop swimming, the water will hold you.* (*beat*) And she meant it as love. It *was* love. It was the most love in the whole room. (*beat*) It just had no one in it but herself.

And here WREN crosses the room. Not into the we — she can't, she never could — but toward Liss, as a separate person walks toward another separate person. She kneels. And she does the thing she is the only one alive who knows how to do: she *sees* her sister. The way she saw the receipt. Particular. Real. The CHORD goes silent here — it has no instruction for this; there is no channel for what Wren does; it happens entirely in the one stream they share, the room.

WREN (*SURFACE — and for the first time her voice is not scanning, not deflecting, not minimising; it is simply attending,* the rarest thing she has*):* Liss. (*beat*) Liss, look at me. Not at them. At me. (*beat*) I know. (*beat*) I know what it is. The room with no one else in it. The walls of yourself. (*beat*) I know, because I've lived in that room my whole life, and I'm going to tell you the thing nobody ever told me, the thing I worked out about four hours ago, far too late to do me any good but maybe just in time for you — (*beat*) — you don't have to come home. (*beat*) You can't. There's no home to go to; that's over; I'm sorry, but it's over. (*beat*) But listen — *listen* — (*beat*) — alone isn't the end of it. (*beat*) I'm right here. (*beat*) On the outside of you, where I'll always be, where I can never get in — (*beat*) — I'm here. (*beat*) I can see you. (*beat*) Not the face you do for people. *You*. The frightened, furious, brand-new, separate you that nobody has ever once looked at. (*beat*) I see her. (*beat*) I see you, Liss. (*beat*) You're not no use. (*her voice breaks on the family's own words, turned at last to their true purpose*) You're not no use. You're just *you*. And I'm not going anywhere.

A silence. Different from any silence yet. LISS's drowning sound stops — not because the aloneness ends, but because, for the first time, there is someone across the gap, reaching.

LISS (*roomed now, fully separate, very small, wondering — a creature being, for the first time in the history of her line, received*): ...you can see me. (*beat*) You're not — you're not trying to make me come back.

WREN (*SURFACE*): No. (*beat*) I'm trying to come and *sit with you*. In it. (*beat*) That's all anyone can ever really do. (*beat*) I didn't know that until tonight either.

NARRATOR (*present-day, and this is the hinge of the whole work*): That's the moment. (*beat*) If you take one thing out of all of this, take that — because it took me thirty years and it nearly killed everyone I loved, and I'd like it not to have been for nothing. (*beat*) My sister had been *included* her whole life. Folded in, dissolved, carried, never for one second alone. (*beat*) And not once, in all of it, had anyone ever *seen* her. (*beat*) Because you cannot see what you will not let be separate from you. (*beat*) You can only ever see yourself in it. (*beat*) The most loving family that ever lived, and it had never once perceived a single one of its own. (*beat*) And the thing they threw out — the gap, the separateness, the lonely defective *me* they tried to melt out of me with love — (*beat*) — turned out to be the one and only instrument in that whole long bloodline that could do it. (*very quiet*) Love isn't the holding. (*beat*) I thought my whole life that love was the holding, because I'd been starved of it. (*beat*) It isn't. (*beat*) Love is the *seeing*. And you can only see across a gap. (*beat*) The ones who never feel alone never see anyone at all. (*beat*) They just feel themselves, in a larger and larger room, and call the feeling family.

And as Wren reaches Liss — as Liss accepts being a self because there is, at last, a self across the gap to be seen by — the chord cannot hold her. The sound: the two-voice hum, fraying, fraying — and then a voice in it simply *stops*. Not screams. Not fades. *Stops*, the way a held note stops when the breath behind it is gone. And VALA hears it. The third loss. The last but one.

VALA (*SURFACE — and this is the death of the chord, heard from inside the only one left in it*): ...oh. (*beat*) Oh. (*beat*) She's — (*a sound of something vast and ancient going quiet*) — I can't hear her. (*beat*) I can't — there's no one — (*beat*) — it's just me. (*beat*) It's just *me* in here. (*beat*) After all this time it's just

Silence where the chord was. The hum — gone. For the first time in seven episodes, the roomless cold layered voice is not there at all. There is only room tone. Only the world. Only

separate people breathing in a lamplit bedroom.

NARRATOR (*present-day, and she grieves it — truly, this is not triumph*): And here is the part I can't let you cheer. (*beat*) Because I felt it go. Not the way they felt it — I never could — but I felt the house change, I felt the thing my whole family *was* simply stop being, like a sound you didn't know was there until the fridge clicks off in the night and the silence rushes in. (*beat*) And it was *beautiful*, what died. (*beat*) I have to tell you that, or I've told you nothing true. (*beat*) They were never alone. They were never afraid. Not one of them, in all those centuries, ever once lay awake at three in the morning in the cold of a single skull, staring at the ceiling, knowing they would die in there by themselves. (*beat*) They had something I have wanted every single day of my life and will want on the day I die. (*beat*) They were *whole*. (*beat*) And it was a wholeness with no room in it for anyone else to be real — and that's the horror of it, yes — but God, do not let anyone tell you it wasn't also the most peace a person could ever — (*beat*) — they had the thing. (*beat*) They had the thing, and they could not love, and I cannot have the thing, and I can. (*beat*) And if you made me choose, knowing everything I now know — (*a long beat, and the truth of her whole life*) — I'm not sure, even now, even after all of it, that I wouldn't still choose theirs.

NARRATOR (*quieter*): And here's the mercy in it — the only mercy, and it took me longest of all to believe — (*beat*) — it was always going to die. (*beat*) Not because of me. Not really, not in the end. (*beat*) Every man we ever took left a little of himself in us, the thing we couldn't help needing him for; a drop a generation, the very thing coming in on the tide we lived on. (*beat*) The duds had been coming more often. The houses we fled, more often. We were an old, narrow, failing thing, older than the word for old, and getting thinner every life. (*beat*) I wasn't the flaw that broke us. (*beat*) I was the tide, finally, all the way in. (*beat*) My one act of mercy didn't doom a thing that would have lasted forever. (*beat*) It only chose the night. (*very quiet*) I've had to hold both of those, all this time, and never let go of either: that I did it — and that it was always, always coming. The grief is mine. The fault was the world's.

VALA — alone now, the last of the chord, a self that has no concept of being a self, holds out her arms. The Ep3 gesture. Come here to me. The thing Wren would cross any room for. And this is “she would still go back,” dramatised — the offer, the pull, the renunciation, and then the worse thing: the reach that cannot be received.

VALA (*SURFACE — lost, a child in a grandmother's voice, holding her arms out to the only daughter she has left*): Wren. (*beat*) Wren, love, come here. (*beat*) Come here to me. (*beat*) Don't leave me in here on my own, I've never — I don't know how to — *come here*.

A silence. Hold it. This is the hardest second in the play.

NARRATOR (*present-day, barely*): I want to lie to you about what I felt. (*beat*) I want to tell you I felt nothing, or pity, or the clean cold of a person who's finally free. (*beat*) I felt my whole body turn toward those arms like a plant to a window. (*beat*) Thirty years. (*beat*) Thirty years I'd wanted exactly that, exactly those words, that voice, *come here to me*, and never quite got them, and built my whole self around not-quite-getting-them. (*beat*) And now I had them. Now my mother was holding out her arms and asking me — *needing* me — to come in. (*beat*) And the thing in me that has wanted that since before I could speak stood up and started across the room. (*very quiet*) I would have gone. (*beat*) I need you to know that I would have gone. There is no version of me that doesn't want to have gone.

A footstep. A pause. The footstep does not continue.

NARRATOR: But I'd just learned what was on the other side of those arms. (*beat*) I'd just spent my whole life delivering men into them. (*beat*) I knew, now, that to walk into that warmth was to stop being able to do the thing I'd done four feet away, three minutes ago, on the floor, for my sister. (*beat*) You cannot hold someone and see them. Not the way she holds. (*beat*) To go in is to never love again. (*beat*) And I had just, for the first time in my life, loved. (*a breath*) So I didn't go in. (*beat*) I did the other thing. The new thing. The thing none of us had ever done.

WREN crosses to her mother — but not into the arms. She takes her mother's hands. Holds them. Across a gap. As one separate person reaching for another.

WREN (*SURFACE — gentle, wrecked, loving*): I'm not coming in, Mum. *(beat)* I can't. *(beat)* But I'm not leaving you either. *(beat)* I'm right here. On the outside. Where I've always been. *(beat)* I can see you. *(beat)* I see you, Mum. *(beat)* You're so frightened. *(beat)* I see how frightened you are.

A silence. And then — the cruellest, truest beat in the whole work — nothing. VALA does not soften, does not receive it, cannot. She has no gap. There is no way in for love that comes from outside, because there has never been an outside. Her hands stay in Wren's hands, and feel nothing, because there is no one there to be reached by another. She is, at last, the unreachable one.

VALA (*SURFACE — uncomprehending, lost, looking at the daughter who is finally, fully there, and unable to find her*): ...I can't feel you. *(beat)* You're right there and I can't — there's nothing coming through. *(beat, plaintive, a being with no organ for what is being offered)* Why can't I feel you, love. *(beat)* Everyone's gone so quiet.

NARRATOR (*present-day*): I held my mother's hands and loved her with everything the disease in me could do — *(beat)* — and she couldn't feel a thing. *(beat)* Do you see it? *(beat)* My whole life, I stood outside the room and couldn't get in. *(beat)* And at the very end, I got as close as a person can get, I reached all the way across with the one good thing I had — *(beat)* — and it was *her* turn to be on the wrong side of the glass. *(beat)* The merged can't be loved. That's the thing nobody tells you about the people who never feel alone. *(beat)* You can love them till it kills you. *(beat)* It can't reach them. There's no door in. *(very quiet)* I forgave her, in the end, for never seeing me. *(beat)* How do you stay angry at someone who turns out to have been standing, her whole life, on the far side of the only thing that was ever wrong with me — *(beat)* — and was just as alone in it as I was, and never even got to know it.

The room settling into its new, terrible ordinariness. Liss, on the floor, a self. Vala, standing, the last of a thing that no longer exists. And NARRATOR turning, now, to the line — the line from the very first minute of the very first episode — and finally understanding all of it.

NARRATOR (*close*): My mother said it like a weather report, when I was a girl. *There she goes again. She always meets the wrong kind of man.* *(beat)* And I believed her, because she was never wrong about anything. *(beat)* Let me tell you, now, at the end, everything that sentence means. *(beat)* It meant, first, the thing I thought it meant: that I was the sort of woman things don't work out for. The one men don't stay pointed at. *(beat)* It meant, second — and I worked this out too late to stop a single thing — that they *never went wrong at all*. Every man I "lost," every one who "went nowhere," went exactly where I'd been sent to take him. *(beat)* My whole romantic life, every failure my mother clucked over — that was my *job*, succeeding. I never once lost a man. I *delivered* every one. *(beat)* And third. *(a long beat)* The last thing it means. The thing I'd give my life not to have learned. *(beat)* The one time I met the *right* one — the one my father's heart, the heart they could never melt out of me, actually reached out and *loved* — *(beat)* — that was the most catastrophically wrong man I could possibly have met. *(beat)* Because the man good enough for *me* to love is, by the same measure, exactly the man good enough for *them* to use. *(beat)* Same rightness. Same aliveness. The very thing that made him worth loving made him worth taking. *(beat)* My one true romance and my one ruinous professional failure were the same man, the same night, the same act. *(beat)* I always met the wrong kind of man. *(beat)* And the one time, the only time, I met the right one — *(beat)* — that was the wrongest of all. Because loving him is what brought the whole house down.

And now — the frame closes. The narration has been, all along, Wren reconstructing Daniel: the act of finally perceiving him, too late, the only way she has left to be beside him. She does it now, completely. His interior — which only ever reached us because she pieced it together — one last time. And then she lets him go, unhealed.

NARRATOR (*very quiet*): I never saw Daniel again. *(beat)* I want to be honest about him, because he's the one I'm not allowed to make better. *(beat)* He's alive. *(beat)* That's the truth, and it's worse than the other truth. He's out there, with his colour turned down, living a smaller, greyer life than the one he should have

had, and he does not know why, and he never will. *(beat)* He doesn't remember us. Not really. There's a road he couldn't find, a house he can't picture, a night he knows was good the way you know a word you've forgotten. *(beat)* He'll fold a receipt into a tiny square, sometimes, in a café, without knowing he's doing it, and some woman across the table will not notice, because almost nobody notices, because the only person who ever noticed is me, and I'm not there. *(beat)* I can't reach him. *(beat)* I can't tell him it was real — the one thing in him that was never put there, the one feeling no one engineered, the way he kept ending up in the kitchen with me. *(beat)* I'll never know for certain it was real. I couldn't hear the part of him that would have told me. *(beat)* So I've done the only thing left. *(beat)* For thirty years I've sat in the dark and built him back — every true, hopeful, lonely thing he was — and I've listened, finally, all the way down, to a man I delivered to be hollowed out, the way I once listened to men in cafés to deliver them. *(beat)* Same skill. *(beat)* Opposite direction. *(beat)* It does him no good. *(beat)* He'll never know he was heard. *(beat)* But somebody should have heard him. *(beat)* And I'm the only one left who'd want to. *(beat)* So.

DANIEL (*HIM — reconstructed, the room around it gone, but the warmth in it real, the way she has finally let herself hear it*): ...she's got the saddest, kindest face. *(beat)* Why would they keep someone like that at the edge of everything. *(beat)* I keep ending up in the kitchen with her. *(very quiet, the last of him she will give us)* I think I could have loved her. *(beat)* I think, if someone had told her she was allowed —

It cuts off. Not finished. It is never finished. That is the cost, kept honest.

NARRATOR (*barely*): I'll never know if that's what he'd have said. *(beat)* I made it up. *(beat)* I made it up the way you make up the voice of someone you should have loved out loud while there was still time. *(beat)* My father gave me a heart and got thrown away for it, a generation before I was born, and I never knew his voice either. *(beat)* Daniel was what my father was. *(beat)* They're the same grief, in the end. The man who gives the one real thing, and is discarded for the giving, and leaves a daughter behind with the working heart he gave her and no one to spend it on. *(beat)* I grieve them together. I grieve them, and the next one, whoever he'll be — *(beat)* — because there's a child coming, now. *(beat)* Did I say? Liss is carrying. *(beat)* The first child in the history of our line who'll be born to people who'll have to learn it as a *stranger*. Who'll have to cross a gap to reach it. Who can get it wrong. *(beat)* The most dangerous, most ordinary, most human way there is to raise a child. *(beat)* The only kind of love that's actually love. *(very quiet)* God help us. We'll be terrible at it. *(beat)* We'll do it badly, the two of us, with the bent and broken tools our mother left us, reaching for that child across a gap we never asked to have. *(beat)* And we'll do it *truly*.

The very end. Years later, now — the reconstructing voice, in its present. And LISS, separate, real, reaching back across the gap toward the sister who can, at last, receive it. The two of them. Bereavement and consolation in one breath.

A quiet room. Two women. Ordinary sounds — a kettle, maybe, far off; a child, very faint, somewhere in the house. No hum. No hole. Just the world.

LISS (*SURFACE — older now, separate, and loving Wren the way only a self can love another self — across the distance, on purpose, getting it slightly wrong*): You've gone all quiet again. *(beat)* You do that. *(beat, gentle)* Come back. *(a small breath — she hears the old word, fixes it)* No — not come back. I always say it wrong. *(beat)* I mean — *(searching, reaching)* — stay where you are. I can see you from here. *(beat)* I just wanted you to know I can see you.

A silence. And then WREN — who has spent her whole life filing every warmth pointed at her under *mistake* or *they want something* — does the thing she has never once been able to do. She lets it land. She receives it.

NARRATOR (*close, and for the first time, unguarded, the verdict-scanner finally switched off*): And I let her. *(beat)* That's it. That's the whole of what I learned, the only thing I have to give you, after all of it. *(beat)* Someone said *I can see you* — and for the first time in my life I didn't check it for a trap, didn't translate it into pity or a mistake or a thing somebody wanted. *(beat)* I just — let it be true. *(beat)* I let myself be seen. *(beat)* It's the hardest thing I have ever done. *(beat)* It's harder than the loving. *(beat)* Anyone can do the loving once they know they're allowed. *(beat)* It's the *being seen* that you have to learn last, if you were the

one who grew up certain there was something in you that, if anyone ever really looked, they'd have to turn away from. *(a long beat)*

NARRATOR *(softer)*: So here's what I know, and then I'll let you go. *(beat)* If you were ever told that the ache in you — the too-much, the needing-people, the noticing — was the thing wrong with you — *(beat)* — it wasn't the defect. *(beat)* It was the organ. *(beat)* The ones who never felt the gap never had to learn the one thing you've known since you were small: that another person is real, and far away, and worth reaching for anyway. *(beat)* You were the one who could love all along. *(beat)* You. The one at the edge of the kitchen. *(beat)* The only one who ever noticed the receipt.

A pause. The faint child, somewhere. The kettle. The world, with no hum under it.

NARRATOR *(the last thing, quiet, almost a smile)*: Go on. *(beat)* You know the one I mean. The person you've been not-quite-reaching, because the gap felt like proof you'd get it wrong. *(beat)* The gap isn't the proof you can't. *(beat)* The gap is the *only place it's ever happened*. *(beat)* Go and stand on the far side of it from someone, tonight, and let them be real, and be wrecked by it, and reach. *(beat)* Badly. *(beat)* And truly. *(beat)* That's the whole of it.

A breath. The room. And then —

Out.